IB English A: Language and Literature · Paper 2

Death and the Maiden

Ariel Dorfman · A Paper 2 guide

Comparative essay preparation
Event bank · Quote bank · Issue arcs by act and across the play
Pairing notes · Self-test

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How to use this guide

Every event, claim and quotation in this guide is tied to the playscript. References take the form II.1.95: Act II, Scene 1, line 95, where each line of dialogue counts as one line, counted from the start of the scene. A reference with a plus sign, such as II.1.95+, points to the text that follows that line: a stage direction, or the continuation of a long line of dialogue. Act I, Scene 3 has no dialogue at all.

> **Built for Paper 2.** The issue arcs trace each concern through Acts I, II and III, so you can see how the play's position develops. The pairing notes at the end of the exam section show how the play sets up against *The Visit* and *The Things They Carried*.

The examination

Course and paper	IB Diploma English A: Language and Literature, Paper 2: the comparative essay on two literary works studied in the course. Paper 2 is not a set-text exam: the questions are general, they do not name any work, and there are no extracts.
Format	1 hour 45 minutes at both SL and HL. Answer one of four general questions, comparing two of the literary works you have studied. 30 marks; 35% of the final mark at SL and 25% at HL. Check these figures against your current subject guide.
Criteria	A Knowledge, understanding and interpretation (10); B Analysis and evaluation (10); C Focus and organisation (5); D Language (5). Your iSWIM P2 checklist splits B into B1 and B2.
What this means for revision	You will not know the question in advance, so you cannot prepare a single essay. You prepare a small number of moments from each work that you know in detail, grouped by issue, and you rehearse how each work handles those issues differently. That is what the issue arcs, the event bank and the quote bank in this guide are for. Comparison must be structural: every paragraph needs both works.

iSWIM for Paper 2. Use the five guiding questions on every prompt.

i	What is the issue of significance? The concern beneath the prompt's topic word.
S	Why does it matter? The human, social or philosophical stakes.
W	What does each author want you to understand about it?
I	How does each author get you to understand it? Structure, form, characterisation, voice, staging.
M	What does each work position its audience towards, and what does the comparison reveal? The essay-level M comes from the tension between M(A) and M(B).

Write each paragraph with PEACE ACT: Point, Evidence, Analysis, Comparison, Extension, Audience, Context, Tie-back. Characters do not exist: reach through Paulina, Gerardo and Roberto to the choices Dorfman makes with them.

iSWIM tells you how to plan. Thinking with iSWIM tells you how to think. Your text-type guide tells you what to notice and what to call it.

Context

Facts about the writer and period are attributed to a named source. Facts about the work come from the work.

Where and when

The play names no country. The characters refer to seventeen years of dictatorship I.1.82 and to Paulina's ordeal fifteen years earlier II.1.41, and she dates the arrest to 6 April 1975 III.1.56. The new government's Investigating Commission and the threat from the Army I.2.39 place the action in a transition from military rule. The DATM revision notes read it as post-Pinochet Chile.

Source: Playscript; DATM revision notes

Theatrical lenses

The DATM lens files read the play through Brecht (the mirror and the refusal of catharsis), Arendt (the banality of the functionary), Kafka (the process without a verdict) and Voltaire. These are interpretive frames to test against the play, not facts about Dorfman's intentions.

Source: DATM lens files 04–06

At a glance

Scene	Setting	Events	Event titles
Scene I.1	Beach house, after midnight	E1–E1	Gerardo comes home late
Scene I.2	The same, later that night	E2–E3	Roberto arrives; Roberto's outrage
Scene I.3	Wordless: Paulina ties Roberto up	E4–E4	The wordless scene
Scene I.4	Before dawn	E5–E5	The accusation
Scene II.1	Midday	E6–E8	The trial and the terms; Recognition and the fantasies of revenge; The dead and the living
Scene II.2	Afternoon	E9–E10	Gerardo and Roberto; Gerardo's outburst
Scene III.1	Evening into dawn: the confession	E11–E15	The old wound; Paulina's testimony; The confession; The test; The mirror
Scene III.2	A concert hall, months later	E16–E16	The concert

Event bank

16 numbered events in order. Read one scene for close revision, or E1 to E16 straight through as the arc of the whole work.

Scene I.1

E1 Gerardo comes home late I.1.2–89

Paulina, alone with a gun, waits for Gerardo I.1, opening+. He explains a flat tyre and a stranger who gave him a lift I.1.6. The real subject is the president's Investigating Commission: Paulina points out that it only investigates cases that ended in death I.1.64.

Why it matters. The play opens on the limits of the new state's justice before the doctor arrives. The gun is on stage in the first minute.

Scene I.2

E2 Roberto arrives I.2.2–58

The stranger, Dr Roberto Miranda, returns late at night, having heard Gerardo's name on the news I.2.11. Over drinks the men discuss whether the Commission can work I.2.39, and Roberto quotes Nietzsche on the female soul I.2.22. Gerardo invites him to stay the night.

Why it matters. The audience hears the details Paulina will later claim to recognise before it knows they matter.

E3 Roberto's outrage I.2.30–36

Over drinks Roberto regrets that the amnesty protects the old regime's men I.2.30 and declares he would kill all of them I.2.36.

Why it matters. The future accused is first heard as the loudest voice for punishment.

Dig deeper. The revision notes read this as performed outrage, the camouflage of a perpetrator blending into the new order. Is it evidence of guilt, or only evidence that the play has made you suspicious?

Scene I.3

E4 The wordless scene I.3, opening+

Paulina takes the gun and goes into Roberto's room; there is a muffled cry I.3, opening+. When his own headlights sweep the room, Roberto is revealed tied to a chair and gagged I.3, opening+.

Why it matters. Dorfman stages the turning point without a word, and shows the result only as an image in a flash of light.

Scene I.4

E5 The accusation I.4.1–54

Paulina plays Roberto's cassette of Schubert's Death and the Maiden I.4.1+. She tells Gerardo that this is the doctor who played Schubert while she was tortured I.4.13 and announces a trial in the house I.4.54.

Why it matters. The private trial begins as a parody of the courts the new state cannot use.

Dig deeper. Gerardo's response is to call Paulina sick I.4.20. Notice who is diagnosed and who is believed at each point of the play.

Scene II.1

E6 The trial and the terms II.1.7–95

Paulina records everything on the cassette recorder II.1.7. Gerardo threatens that she will have to kill him first II.1.39 and warns how the press will use the episode against the Commission II.1.67. Paulina names what she wants: a confession II.1.95.

Why it matters. The private conflict is framed in the public stakes of the transition.

Dig deeper. The cassette recorder gives a private act the look of official procedure. Is Paulina imitating the Commission, or the interrogation room?

E7 Recognition and the fantasies of revenge II.1.74–95

Paulina tells Gerardo she recognises Roberto's skin and smell as well as his voice II.1.74+. She admits that for years she imagined revenge on men like him II.1.89, including having him raped II.1.91, and that she put these fantasies aside: what she wants is a confession II.1.95.

Why it matters. Dorfman shows the revenge fantasy and its rejection in the same speech. Paulina chooses speech over violence before the audience sees her threaten to kill.

Dig deeper. Her evidence is bodily: voice, skin, smell. What kind of proof is that, and why can no institution in the play hear it?

E8 The dead and the living II.1.68–104

Paulina argues that the Commission deals only with the dead, and she can speak II.1.68. Gerardo tells her she has stayed a prisoner for fifteen years II.1.79. She sends him to persuade Roberto II.1.104.

Why it matters. The play sets the institution against the survivor's need to be heard.

Scene II.2

E9 Gerardo and Roberto II.2.21–39

Alone with Gerardo, Roberto pleads innocence and offers innocent reasons for his Schubert cassette II.2.21. Gerardo proposes indulging her II.2.39: a confession, invented if necessary.

Why it matters. The lawyer coaches a confession, so the play makes its own evidence doubtful.

Dig deeper. Gerardo advises Roberto to invent a confession II.2.30. From this point no account the audience hears is free of his influence.

E10 Gerardo's outburst II.2.50–51

Roberto suggests that the couple are playing good cop and bad cop, and that a real man would kill a wife's rapist II.2.50. Gerardo explodes in mockery of that idea of manhood II.2.51.

Why it matters. The lawyer's anger is turned against the code of violent masculinity, while he goes on defending the man accused of embodying it.

Scene III.1

E11 The old wound III.1.8–17

Paulina and Gerardo return to the night she came home after her release and a woman came out of his bedroom III.1.9. Gerardo's defence is that he was looking for her and is also human III.1.14.

Why it matters. The man who speaks for law and reconciliation is shown asking forgiveness for his own betrayal.

E12 Paulina's testimony III.1.51–56

Gerardo records Paulina telling her story as if in front of the Commission III.1.52, beginning with her name and the date of her arrest, 6 April 1975 III.1.56.

Why it matters. The private trial becomes a rehearsal of the testimony the state will not hear from her.

E13 The confession III.1.57–65

Roberto's confession is heard in the dark, describing the Schubert as a way of gaining prisoners' trust III.1.57+. He writes it out and signs it III.1.65+.

Why it matters. The confession is the play's most detailed account of the torture, and it may have been written by others.

Dig deeper. The confession is clinical: torture described as a medical procedure that keeps prisoners alive III.1.57+, then as curiosity III.1.58. Who wrote these words, and does it matter if they are true anyway?

E14 The test III.1.84–106

Roberto says the confession is false and was built from what Gerardo told him III.1.90. Paulina reveals that she planted small variations in her story to Gerardo, and Roberto corrected most of them III.1.99. She will kill him not for guilt but because he has not repented III.1.99, and counts towards ten.

Why it matters. The play hands the audience a test of guilt and then refuses to let the verdict settle.

Dig deeper. The audience never sees the correction happen. It hears Paulina's claim III.1.95+ and Roberto's denial III.1.94. Which do you believe, and why?

E15 The mirror III.1.107

Paulina asks why people like her must always be the ones to make concessions III.1.107. The actors freeze and a giant mirror descends, forcing the audience to look at themselves III.1.107+.

Why it matters. The question of what she does is handed to the audience; we do not see the outcome.

Dig deeper. The scene freezes on a question III.1.107. The audience is shown itself, not the answer.

Scene III.2

E16 The concert III.2.1

Months later Gerardo talks to admirers about the Commission's final report III.2.1. Roberto appears, perhaps real, perhaps an illusion III.2.1+. The quartet plays; Paulina and Roberto look at each other, and she faces the stage and the mirror III.2.1+.

Why it matters. Reconciliation is staged as a society that sits in the same room as its torturers and listens to the same music.

Dig deeper. Gerardo praises people for acting without any personal vendetta III.2.1+. Who is that line for?

Characters

Paulina Salas

A survivor of detention and torture under the dictatorship, married to Gerardo; arrested on 6 April 1975 III.1.56.

- Identifies Roberto by music, voice and phrases rather than sight I.4.13.
- Demands speech, not death II.1.95, and claims the right to be heard II.1.68.
- Sets a trap that seems to prove Roberto's guilt III.1.99.
- Refuses the role of the one who always concedes III.1.107.

Arc. From hiding with a gun (I.1) to judge (II–III) to a silent figure in the concert hall (III.2).

Gerardo Escobar

A lawyer newly appointed to the president's Investigating Commission I.2.11.

- Speaks for due process and moderation, and fears for the Commission II.1.67.
- Calls Paulina mad in private II.2.39 and helps produce the confession III.1.90.
- Asks forgiveness for his affair III.1.14.

Arc. Ends successful and public III.2.1: the transition's face.

Dr Roberto Miranda

The doctor who helps Gerardo on the road and whom Paulina accuses.

- Arrives because of the Commission I.2.11.
- Explains his cassette innocently II.2.21.
- Confesses, then retracts III.1.86, and argues against the cycle of revenge III.1.104.

Arc. The play never decides him; his final appearance may be an illusion III.2.1+.

Themes

Each theme is traced through the work. Quotation numbers refer to the quote bank.

Justice, due process and revenge

The play sets a private trial against public justice that cannot reach the living. Dorfman never lets the audience settle on which is just.

Act I	The Commission investigates only deaths I.1.64. Paulina announces her own trial I.4.54. Quotations: Q2, Q5, Q6, Q8
Act II	The trial acquires procedure and terms: recording II.1.7, a defender, and a demand for confession rather than death II.1.95. Quotations: Q9, Q10, Q11, Q16, Q19
Act III	The charge moves from guilt to repentance III.1.99, and Roberto names the cycle of revenge III.1.104. The verdict is never shown. Quotations: Q28, Q29, Q30, Q32, Q33, Q36

The whole arc. From a trial the state will not hold, to a trial with no possible verdict.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - What is the difference between justice and revenge, and at what point in the play does Paulina's trial cross from one to the other, if it does?
> - Who has the right to judge? Paulina sets herself up as judge I.4.54; Gerardo appeals to due process II.1.6. Which claim does the play make stronger?
> - Is certainty necessary for justice? The play gives Paulina a test that seems to prove guilt and then lets Roberto deny it.

Truth, memory and evidence

Paulina's evidence is sensory and remembered; Roberto's confession is coerced and possibly scripted. The play offers proof and withholds certainty.

Act I	The audience hears Roberto's Nietzsche before it means anything I.2.22; Paulina identifies him by music and voice I.4.13. Quotations: Q4, Q5, Q7
Act II	Paulina claims the right to speak II.1.68; Roberto offers innocent explanations II.2.21. Quotations: Q9, Q12, Q13, Q14, Q15, Q16, Q17, Q18
Act III	Paulina testifies III.1.52; Roberto confesses, then says the confession was written for him III.1.90; her test seems to prove him guilty III.1.99; the last stage direction leaves him real or imagined III.2.1+. Quotations: Q23, Q24, Q25, Q26, Q27, Q28, Q35

The whole arc. Each act adds evidence and each act weakens it, so the audience ends where Paulina began: certain without proof, or doubtful without reason.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Can the body know something the mind cannot prove? Paulina recognises voice, skin and smell II.1.74+.
> - Can a coerced confession be true, and can a free denial be a lie? The play refuses to let you know.
> - What does your wish to know whether Roberto is guilty reveal about your own need for a resolved story?

Transition, the state and reconciliation

The Escobars' house is a small version of the country after dictatorship: the victim, the lawyer of the new order and the alleged agent of the old regime under one roof.

Act I	The new government's Commission is fragile I.2.39. Quotations: Q2, Q3, Q6
Act II	Gerardo fears the episode will destroy the Commission II.1.67. Quotations: Q11, Q15
Act III	The marriage repeats the national formula III.1.17; the final scene shows the report delivered III.2.1 while victim and torturer share a concert hall. Quotations: Q22, Q23, Q30, Q31, Q33, Q34, Q36

The whole arc. Reconciliation is shown working, and shown costing the person least able to bear it.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Who benefits when a nation chooses to move forward rather than confront what was done?
> - Can reconciliation exist without accountability? Compare Paulina's demand for a confession with the Commission's final report III.2.1.
> - When the state and the individual want different things, whose needs come first, and can a state that overrides the individual still claim to guarantee freedom?

Gender and power

The play stages a woman's testimony judged by two men, one who loves her and one she says raped her. Who is called mad, and who repairs the damage, are recurring questions.

Act I	The first quarrel is about who fixes things I.1.10; Roberto's Nietzsche concerns the female soul I.2.22. Quotations: Q1, Q4
Act II	Gerardo protects Roberto with his body II.1.39 and calls Paulina mad in private II.2.39. Quotations: Q10, Q14, Q19
Act III	Paulina asks why people like her must always concede III.1.107.

Quotations: Q20, Q32

The whole arc. Paulina holds the gun throughout and is still the one asked to give way.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - How does gender shape who is believed? Track every moment Paulina is called sick, mad or ill I.4.20 II.2.39.
> - Roberto offers a code of manhood in which a husband kills his wife's rapist II.2.50; Gerardo mocks it. What does the play suggest about men speaking for women's injuries?

Complicity and concealment

Gerardo is the play's voice of law and openness, and he deceives: in the past, by his affair, and in the present, by coaching the confession.

Act I	He keeps the details of his appointment from Paulina at first I.1.89. Quotations: –
Act II	He agrees to indulge Paulina by obtaining a confession II.2.39. Quotations: Q18
Act III	The affair is reopened III.1.9 and Roberto says Gerardo told him what to write III.1.90. Quotations: Q20, Q21, Q22, Q26, Q27

The whole arc. The defender of transparency is the play's most consistent concealer.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Does private dishonesty compromise public moral authority? The play's representative of liberal democracy is also its most consistent concealer.
> - If institutions of transitional justice are run by people with their own secrets, what does that say about the institutions?

Art and atrocity

Schubert's quartet is the torturer's music and the victim's favourite. Its return in the final scene asks whether art can be shared with the people who used it.

Act I	Paulina plays the cassette taken from Roberto's car I.4.1+. Quotations: Q7
Act II	Roberto lists other composers to make the cassette innocent II.2.21. Quotations: –
Act III	The confession explains the music as a way to win trust III.1.57+; the play ends with the quartet in a concert hall III.2.1+. Quotations: Q25

The whole arc. Paulina wins back the music, and has to hear it in the same room as Roberto.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Can beauty survive being used in atrocity? The quartet that accompanied torture ends the play in a concert hall III.2.1+.
> - Does Paulina win back the music, or does she only learn to listen to it in the same room as the man she accuses?

Theme and scene grid

Reading a row from left to right gives that theme's arc.

Theme	Act I	Act II	Act III
Justice, due process and revenge	Q2, Q5, Q6, Q8	Q9, Q10, Q11, Q16, Q19	Q28, Q29, Q30, Q32, Q33, Q36
Truth, memory and evidence	Q4, Q5, Q7	Q9, Q12, Q13, Q14, Q15, Q16, Q17, Q18	Q23, Q24, Q25, Q26, Q27, Q28, Q35
Transition, the state and reconciliation	Q2, Q3, Q6	Q11, Q15	Q22, Q23, Q30, Q31, Q33, Q34, Q36
Gender and power	Q1, Q4	Q10, Q14, Q19	Q20, Q32
Complicity and concealment		Q18	Q20, Q21, Q22, Q26, Q27
Art and atrocity	Q7		Q25

Dorfman's methods: the playscript

AO3: how the writer creates meanings and effects through language, structure and form.

Unity of place and time

One house, one night and a day: the classical unities compress a nation's transition into a room I.1, opening+.

Three characters and shifting alliances

Each scene changes who is aligned with whom: the men drinking together I.2.22, Paulina and Gerardo against each other II.1.39, the two men alone II.2.39.

The wordless scene

Act I, Scene 3 has no dialogue; the turning point is shown as an image in car headlights I.3, opening+.

Sound: music, sea and the cassette recorder

Schubert played in the house I.4.1+; the recorder as courtroom procedure II.1.7; the confession heard in darkness III.1.57+.

The mirror and the audience

A giant mirror makes the audience look at itself at the moment of decision III.1.107+, and faces the actors in the last scene III.2.1+. A Brechtian reading of this device is set out in the DATM lens file on Dorfman and Brecht.

Withheld resolution

The countdown stops before ten III.1.105; the next scene may show a ghost III.2.1+.

Motifs and symbols

The spare tyre and the nail

The first scene's quarrel about who failed to fix the spare I.1.10 becomes the reason Roberto comes back I.2.15.

Light: moon and headlights

Headlights expose Paulina in the first scene I.1, opening+ and Roberto bound in the third I.3, opening+.

The gun

Introduced before any dialogue I.1, opening+ and fired once in Act I I.4.38.

Dig deeper

The surface overview is in the event bank and issue arcs. These sections take each concern further: how the play works as an argument about a nation, how sound and staging make the audience part of the trial, the case for and against Roberto, and the critical lenses in the course materials. Every claim about the play is referenced; readings from the course materials are named.

The play as a national microcosm

On the surface. Three people in a beach house over one night and a day.

The revision notes read the house as the nation in small: the living room becomes a courtroom I.4.54, an interrogation room II.1.7 and a negotiating table II.1.104. The personal quarrel is a political one.

Each character carries a public position. Paulina is the survivor whose case the Commission will not hear II.1.68. Gerardo is the new order's lawyer, anxious about how the press will use the episode II.1.67. Roberto is the professional who may have served the old order and now speaks the language of the new I.2.36.

The marriage repeats the national argument. Gerardo asks Paulina to let go of the past II.1.80, and she hears in it the demand to forget II.1.79+. When the affair returns, he asks for forgiveness in the same words III.1.16.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - If the house is the nation, what is the gun?
> - Can a society heal without retribution? Can justice exist without certainty?

Source: DATM revision notes, section 2

Sound: Schubert, the tape and the concert hall

On the surface. The play is named after a piece of music, and the music recurs.

Schubert's quartet acts almost as a fourth character. Paulina plays it in the house I.4.1+; the confession explains it as a way of winning prisoners' trust III.1.57+; the play ends with it in public III.2.1+.

The cassette recorder formalises the trial II.1.7 and then makes truth a matter of transcription: Roberto copies his recorded words in his own hand III.1.58+. In the dark, his recorded voice overlaps with Paulina's and with the music III.1.57+, so the audience cannot separate testimony from confession.

Paulina keeps the confession as insurance: if harm comes to her or Gerardo, it goes to the newspapers II.1.98. Evidence becomes a weapon rather than a step towards a verdict.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Why does Dorfman put Mozart's Dissonant Quartet, not Schubert, under the mirror III.1.107+?
> - Whose truths are amplified by the sound design, and whose are drowned out?

Source: DATM revision notes, section 3

The audience as judge, jury and Commission

On the surface. The audience watches a private trial.

Dorfman withholds the verdict at the moment of decision. The action freezes, the Mozart begins and a mirror descends between the actors and the audience III.1.107+; lights pick out spectators two or three at a time III.1.107+.

In the final scene Gerardo and Paulina sit facing the mirror with their backs to the spectators III.2, opening+, so the theatre audience and the concert audience are one. The notes read this as the audience cast as the national public, the people to whom the Commission reports.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Were you, by the mirror, hoping Paulina would shoot? What does that tell you?
> - How much certainty do you need before you would convict Roberto?

Source: DATM revision notes, section 4

The question of guilt

On the surface. Is Roberto the doctor?

The case against him. Paulina's bodily recognition II.1.74+; the Schubert cassette in his car I.4.1+; the Nietzsche he quotes I.2.22, which Paulina remembers her torturer quoting II.1.87; the clinical detail of the confession III.1.58; and the planted errors he corrected III.1.99.

The case for him. No document, witness or face supports the identification. He offers innocent reasons for the cassette II.2.21. The confession was coached II.2.30 and he says it was invented III.1.88; he says the corrected name came from Gerardo III.1.94. The audience never sees the correction itself.

The notes conclude that the play does not convict Roberto so much as expose how collective trauma can distort justice. That is one reading; the play also gives Paulina the last look III.2.1+.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - List the evidence you would admit in a court and the evidence you believe. Are the lists the same?
> - Does Paulina need Roberto to be guilty, or to repent III.1.99?

Source: DATM revision notes, sections 5–6

Lens: Brecht and epic theatre

On the surface. The play looks like a conventional realist drama: one place, one night, three characters.

The lens file argues that Dorfman uses Brechtian estrangement inside an apparently Aristotelian form. The refusal of a verdict, the music that comments rather than illustrates, and the mirror all stop the audience losing itself in the story and push it to judge.

It reads Gerardo as the audience's representative: the reasonable liberal whose responses II.1.6 model how a well-meaning spectator thinks, and whose limits the play exposes. It also notes where Dorfman departs from Brecht: he uses the body and emotion as political instruments rather than keeping the audience at a distance from them.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Is Death and the Maiden a Brechtian play, or a realist play with Brechtian moments?
> - Does the mirror estrange the audience, or implicate it emotionally?

Source: DATM lens file 06: Dorfman's playscript through Brecht

Lens: Arendt and Kafka on the bureaucracy of justice

On the surface. The Commission is a good institution with limits.

The lens file uses Arendt's idea of the banality of evil, harm done by people who stop thinking and follow process, and Kafka's The Trial, where the law is inaccessible to the person it concerns. Paulina stands before an institution built for cases like hers whose remit excludes her I.1.64.

Roberto's confession offers a test: it describes the doctor's role in procedural, almost medical terms III.1.57+. The file asks whether impunity is produced by individual malice or by a structure that produces it without anyone intending it.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - If Gerardo's role requires him to manage Paulina's claim rather than advance it, is he her ally or the system's agent?
> - Is the doctor in the confession a sadist, a functionary, or both?

Source: DATM lens file 05: Arendt and Kafka

Lens: Arendt and Voltaire on forgiveness, torture and anger

On the surface. The play asks whether Paulina should forgive.

The lens file sets Arendt's account of forgiveness, which releases people from the consequences of past acts, against Voltaire's fury at torture and arbitrary power. Arendt helps read the demand for repentance III.1.99; Voltaire defends the victim's anger as a rational response, not madness, which is how Gerardo and Roberto describe it II.2.39.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Can forgiveness be demanded by a state, or only given by a victim?
> - Is Paulina's anger reasonable? Who in the play says it is not, and why?

Source: DATM lens file 04: Arendt and Voltaire

Lens: liberty, freedom and the individual against the state

On the surface. The country is now free.

The liberty lens distinguishes negative liberty (freedom from interference) from positive liberty (the real capacity to act) and adds Pettit's republican liberty (freedom from domination). Paulina is no longer imprisoned, yet Gerardo himself says she is still a prisoner II.1.79; the men who held her may still live freely around her II.1.80.

The companion question asks whose needs come first when the state and the individual want different things. Gerardo puts the Commission first II.1.67; Paulina asks why people like her must always concede III.1.107.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Is the end of active harm enough to call someone free?
> - Can a state that overrides the individual still claim to guarantee freedom?

Source: DATM lens files 02 and 03

Essential questions on justice

On the surface. Use these to open any discussion or essay plan.

What is the difference between justice and revenge? Who has the right to judge? Can truth exist without confession? What does a society owe its victims? How does power shape whose suffering is recognised? Is certainty necessary for justice? What role does memory play in the pursuit of justice? Can reconciliation exist without accountability? How does gender shape the experience and performance of justice? Is justice achievable in a fundamentally unjust system? When the state and the individual want different things, whose needs take precedence?

Source: DATM lens files 01 and 02: essential questions

Quote bank

36 quotations in order, each checked against the text.

Scene I.1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q1	I.1.10	PAULINA: “His wife. Always got to be the wife who has to fix everything.” A domestic quarrel about a spare tyre sets up the question of who repairs the damage. Gender and power
Q2	I.1.64	PAULINA: “Doesn’t it only investigate the cases that ended in death?” The limit of the state’s justice is named in the first scene: the living are outside its remit. Justice Transition

Scene I.2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q3	I.2.11	ROBERTO: “I heard your name on the news” The public appointment brings the stranger to the door. Transition
Q4	I.2.22	ROBERTO: “You know what Nietzsche once wrote” A casual remark that will become evidence; the audience hears it before it means anything. Truth Gender and power
Q5	I.2.36	ROBERTO: “I’m for killing the whole bunch of them” The man Paulina will accuse speaks first as an advocate of punishment. Justice Truth
Q6	I.2.39	GERARDO: “the Army is going to fight the Commission all the way” The transition is shown as fragile: the old powers are still armed. Transition Justice

Scene I.4

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q7	I.4.13	PAULINA: “The doctor who played Schubert.” The identification is made through music, not a face. Truth Art and atrocity
Q8	I.4.54	PAULINA: “We’re going to put him on trial, Gerardo, this doctor. Right here. Today.” The courtroom moved into a beach house: a private trial in the absence of a public one. Justice

Scene II.1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q9	II.1.7	PAULINA: “everything you say will be recorded here” The cassette recorder gives the private trial its formal procedure. Justice · Truth
Q10	II.1.39	GERARDO: “you would have to kill me too” Gerardo puts his own body between Paulina and her revenge. Justice · Gender and power
Q11	II.1.68	PAULINA: “the members of the Commission only deal with the dead” The survivor’s complaint: institutions are built for those who cannot speak. Justice · Transition
Q12	II.1.68	PAULINA: “And I can speak” Four words that claim a right the play’s institutions deny. Truth
Q13	II.1.74+	“It’s not only the voice I recognize” Her evidence is the body’s memory: voice, then skin and smell. Truth
Q14	II.1.79	GERARDO: “You’re still a prisoner” The liberal husband diagnoses her; the line is true and also a way of not hearing her. Truth · Gender and power
Q15	II.1.79+	“Forgot? You’re asking me to forget.” The word reconciliation avoids, spoken aloud. Transition · Truth
Q16	II.1.95	PAULINA: “I want him to confess.” She wants speech, not death: the play’s demand is for an acknowledged truth. Justice · Truth

Scene II.2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q17	II.2.21	ROBERTO: “I also like Vivaldi and Mozart and Telemann” An innocent explanation, or a rehearsed one; the play leaves both open. Truth
Q18	II.2.30	GERARDO: “going to have to invent” The lawyer proposes the fabrication that will contaminate every later piece of evidence. Truth · Complicity and concealment

Q19	II.2.39	GERARDO: “When crazy people have power, you’ve got to indulge them.” The lawyer calls the victim mad and proposes to manage her. Gender and power · Justice

Scene III.1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q20	III.1.9	PAULINA: “That bitch came out of your bedroom” The private betrayal behind the public man. Complicity and concealment · Gender and power
Q21	III.1.14	GERARDO: “My God, I’m also human.” Gerardo asks for the forgiveness he denies Paulina’s need for justice. Complicity and concealment
Q22	III.1.17	PAULINA: “Forgive and forget, eh?” The national slogan of reconciliation, applied to the marriage. Transition · Complicity and concealment
Q23	III.1.52	GERARDO: “Just as if you were sitting in front of the Commission.” The testimony is staged for an institution that will never hear it. Transition · Truth
Q24	III.1.54	PAULINA: “My maiden name is Paulina Salas.” The title’s “maiden” returns as her name before marriage and before arrest. Truth
Q25	III.1.57+	“I would put on Schubert because it was a way of gaining the prisoners’ trust” Roberto’s recorded voice. Art used as an instrument of torture; spoken in a confession whose authorship is in doubt. Art and atrocity · Truth
Q26	III.1.88	ROBERTO: “I made it up. We made it up.” “We” brings Gerardo into the fabrication. Truth · Complicity and concealment
Q27	III.1.90	ROBERTO: “Your husband told me what to write” The confession is undermined by the very man who argued for due process. Truth · Complicity and concealment
Q28	III.1.99	PAULINA: “you corrected most of them” Her proof of guilt rests on a test the audience never hears her set. Truth · Justice
Q29	III.1.99	PAULINA: “because you haven’t repented at all” The charge shifts from guilt to repentance, which no court can measure. Justice

Q30	III.1.104	ROBERTO: “So someone did terrible things to you and now you’re doing something terrible to me” The argument against vengeance, made by the man she says is a torturer. Justice · Transition
Q31	III.1.106	ROBERTO: “Oh Paulina, isn’t it time we stopped?” The plea for an end, in the language of reconciliation. Transition
Q32	III.1.107	PAULINA: “why always me who has to bite her tongue” The question of who pays for peace, asked by the person who has always paid. Gender and power · Justice
Q33	III.1.107	PAULINA: “What do we lose by killing one of them?” The question on which the action freezes and the mirror descends. Justice · Transition

Scene III.2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q34	III.2.1	GERARDO: “the Final Report of the Commission” The institutional ending, announced at a social gathering. Transition
Q35	III.2.1+	“He could be real or he could be an illusion” The stage direction refuses the audience certainty about what it sees. Truth
Q36	III.2.1+	“without the hint of seeking a personal vendetta” Gerardo’s public praise of the nation’s restraint, after a private trial in his own house. Transition · Justice

Self-test

7 quick questions; answers with references follow.

1. **What is Gerardo appointed to?**
   A truth commission abroad / The Army / The Supreme Court / The president's Investigating Commission
2. **Why does Roberto first come to the house?**
   He gave Gerardo a lift after a flat tyre and returns with his spare / He is Paulina's doctor / He is lost / He is sent by the Army
3. **What music does Paulina associate with her torturer?**
   Mozart's Dissonant Quartet / Schubert's Death and the Maiden / Telemann / Vivaldi
4. **What does Paulina say she wants from Roberto?**
   A confession / An apology to the Commission / His death / Money
5. **How does Paulina test the confession?**
   She asked his children / She checked his car / She played the tape to Gerardo / She told Gerardo a story with small errors, and Roberto corrected them
6. **What descends at the end of Act III, Scene 1?**
   A cassette recorder / A curtain / A giant mirror / A screen with the Commission's report
7. **Where is the final scene set?**
   A concert hall, months later / A courtroom / The Commission's office / The beach house

Answers

1. The president's Investigating Commission I.2.11
2. He gave Gerardo a lift after a flat tyre and returns with his spare I.2.15
3. Schubert's Death and the Maiden I.4.1+
4. A confession II.1.95
5. She told Gerardo a story with small errors, and Roberto corrected them III.1.99
6. A giant mirror III.1.107+
7. A concert hall, months later III.2.1

Sources

- Ariel Dorfman, *Death and the Maiden* (1991).
- The iSWIM Primer on issues of significance, DATM revision notes, and the DATM lens files (justice, the individual and the state, liberty, Arendt, Kafka, Brecht).
- The iSWIM framework for Paper 2 (five guiding questions, M(A)/M(B), PEACE ACT).